



FOOD STUFF: Prakash at his work place

"Technology only can help us find a solution to the paradox of mass hunger and mounting food stocks."

V. PRAKASH, DIRECTOR, CFTRI

1,300

patents have been filed by CFTRI so far. It has an annual budget of Rs 20 crore, has 500 staff members with nearly 300 being scientists, technologists and engineers.

CENTRAL FOOD TECHNOLOGY RESEARCH INSTITUTE, MYSORE

THE RIGHT FARE

A palace turned into a food laboratory. That is the Central Food Technology Research Institute (CFTRI) at the 167-acre Chaluvamba Palace—earlier the home of the Mysore princess, Chaluvamba. Just a year after India's Independence, the then Mysore maharaja Jayachamarajendra Wadiyar handed over the palace to Jawaharlal Nehru to be used for the significant task of making the country food secure. In October 1950, at an informal gathering of men of eminence like C.V. Raman, the maharaja and Karnataka's first chief minister K.C. Reddy, the CFTRI in Mysore, 110 km from Bangalore, was formally opened. Whether it's a shipload of foodstuff from South Korea or a wheat container from Ukraine or even the results of cola samples, CFTRI scientists will have a say. For Director V. Prakash, who joined as a pool officer 20 years ago, food technology (FT) has assumed a role as important as information technology or bio-technology in the global economy. Imagine FT in food

security, combating post harvest losses amongst other things. The institute not only tests hundreds of food samples every day but also works on technologies for the private sector that enables it to make dosas or chapattis in bulk. "We provide the software to the industry. We are a government laboratory that works like a corporate house," says a proud Prakash. It was CFTRI which introduced the technique to produce baby food from buffalo milk, which India had to import earlier. Because the institute played its part in supporting the white as well as the green revolutions, the father of the green revolution, M.S. Swaminathan, maintains his link with the institute as its chairman. With nearly 300 scientists and technologists across 20 research departments, it is among the largest and the most diversified technology workshops in the world. CFTRI has its stamp on over 300 products and processes and close to 160 commercial technologies.

by Stephen David